THE MWEE IS A POWERFUL EDUCATIONAL FRAMEWORK

The MWEE is a learner-centered framework that focuses on investigations into local environmental issues and leads to informed action. MWEEs are made up of multiple components that include learning both outdoors and in the classroom and are designed to increase environmental literacy by actively engaging students in building knowledge and meaning through hands-on experiences. In these experiences, the core ideas and practices of multiple disciplines are applied to make sense of the relationships between the natural world and society. MWEEs help connect students with their local environment and equip them to make decisions and take actions that contribute to stronger and more sustainable communities.

The MWEE is a unique project-based framework for environmental literacy based on educational best practices supported by evaluation and research. MWEEs feature authentic approaches to learning science, technology, engineering, and math (STEM) and align with state science and social studies standards, including Next Generation Science Standards and the College, Career, and Civic Life (C3) Framework for Social Studies State Standards. MWEEs also reflect research-based instructional models, including place-based education, the North American Association for Environmental Education's (NAAEE) Guidelines for Excellence, and Investigating and Evaluating Environmental Issues and Actions (IEEIA).

While MWEEs can affect a broad array of outcomes — from student health to career awareness — there are four outcomes that stand out as important and timely for the education and environmental fields.

NOT FOCUSED ON WATERSHEDS? THE MWEE IS STILL FOR YOU!

While MWEEs can directly support watershed education by exploring issues such as water quality or land-use impacts, they can also provide rich learning around biodiversity, air quality, food systems, and many other issues that are also an important part of community, environmental, and watershed health.

"So why is the word 'watershed' in the term MWEE?" Watersheds can be connected to virtually every environmental issue, and since every person on Earth lives in a watershed, they are universally relatable and relevant. The intersection of the natural and social systems that make up a watershed provide an opportunity for students to use systems thinking to understand how their actions impact humans, animals, and ecosystems; how natural systems and processes within a watershed affect humans; and how civic engagement factors into the equation. Understanding these relationships requires knowledge and skills from multiple disciplines, as well as skills like active learning, critical thinking, and effective decision making.

We hope you find value in using the MWEE framework with students to explore whatever environmental issues make sense for your classroom.